insisted his comments had been distorted. It made him even more wary of interviews.

The wariness stemmed from the hostile media reaction Modi had encountered in the aftermath of the Gujarat riots. Till then, Modi had assiduously courted the media and, as party general secretary in the 1990s, he was always willing to appear on television debates (see chapter 1). The year 2002 changed the Modi–media equation. He now felt hounded and chose to play 'victim'. He would often say in private conversation, *'Kuch logon ne mann bana liya hai ki Modi gunahgaar hai!'* (Some people have made up their mind that I am guilty.) He especially felt this way towards the mainstream English-language media. In his eyes, the English-language journalistic club along with civil society NGOs were determined to malign his reputation. For Modi, the media is important yet untrustworthy, an ally for publicity, an adversary on issues. It is his intimate enemy—he grudgingly relies on it for feedback but scorns it when it acts as a mirror or sounding board. If he was to open up ahead of the biggest election in his life, it would be to someone he fully trusted.

Rajat Sharma was one such individual. Rajat was one of the original print journalists to switch to television in the early 1990s. He had built his reputation through the programme *Aap ki Adalat* on Zee TV. Designed in a courtroom format, the programme had Rajat play prosecutor with the guest being placed in the confession box before a judge and an audience. By 2004, Rajat had started his own Hindi television channel, India TV, and had become a successful entrepreneur. His channel was now housed in a rather Bollywood-style palatial three-floor building on the Noida highway.

Before plunging into journalism, Rajat had been an activist of the ABVP, the students' wing of the BJP, in the 1970s. He had even been arrested for eleven months in the anti-Emergency movement. That's when he got to know Modi who was then a young RSS pracharak. Their common friend was Jaitley, another rising star in the student politics of the 1970s. Jaitley would become president of the Delhi University students' union; Sharma became general secretary.